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Reading Part 5

The Legacy of the Silk Road

For centuries, the Silk Road served as one of the most influential trade networks in human history, connecting East Asia with Central Asia, the Middle East, and Europe. Rather than being a single road, it consisted of a complex system of land routes that enabled merchants, diplomats, scholars, and travellers to exchange not only goods but also ideas, technologies, religions, and cultures. Historians generally agree that the network began to develop during the Han Dynasty in the second century BC, when the Chinese Empire actively sought stronger political and commercial relationships with western regions.

The modern name "Silk Road" was not used by the people who travelled along these routes. Instead, it was introduced in the nineteenth century by the German geographer Ferdinand von Richthofen, whose research brought international attention to the historical importance of this trading network. His work helped historians understand that silk represented only one of many valuable products transported across Eurasia.

One of the most significant events in the early development of the Silk Road was the journey of Zhang Qian, a Chinese diplomat sent by Emperor Wu of the Han Dynasty. His mission was originally political, but his detailed reports provided valuable information about the people, geography, and trade opportunities that existed west of China. As a result, regular commercial exchange between China and Central Asia became possible.

Trade along the Silk Road involved far more than luxury goods such as silk, jade, spices, and precious metals. Important inventions also travelled across continents. Among them, papermaking had perhaps the greatest long-term impact on world civilization. Once papermaking technology reached the Islamic world and later Europe, books became easier to produce, knowledge spread more rapidly, and education developed at an unprecedented pace.

Centuries later, the rise of the Mongol Empire created one of the safest periods in the history of the Silk Road. Because much of Eurasia came under a single political authority, merchants and travelers could move across enormous distances with greater security than before. During this period, the Venetian explorer Marco Polo successfully travelled to China and later introduced Europeans to many aspects of Asian culture through his famous writings.

Although the Silk Road remained important for many centuries, its influence gradually declined after the development of powerful maritime trade routes. Ocean

transport allowed merchants to move larger quantities of goods more quickly, more cheaply, and with fewer geographical obstacles than traditional overland caravans.

*Questions 30–33: complete the summary. Write **ONE WORD** from the passage for each gap.*

The Silk Road was first developed during the Han Dynasty and became one of the most important trade routes in history. It was later studied by the **(30)** _____ scholar Ferdinand Von Richthofen, who introduced the name "Silk Road" in the nineteenth century. To encourage westward exploration, the Chinese government sent the **(31)** _____ Zhang Qian, whose reports helped open trade between China and Central Asia. Besides transporting valuable goods such as silk and spices, the exchange of **(32)** _____ greatly influenced the development of Europe and other parts of the world. During the time of the Mongol **(33)** _____, the trade routes became much safer, allowing famous travellers such as Marco Polo to travel across Asia.

Questions 34–35: choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

34. What was one important purpose of the Silk Road?

A. To build new cities in Europe.
B. To connect only Chinese provinces.
C. To spread Chinese goods and innovations to the West.
D. To replace sea transportation.

35. Why did maritime trade become more popular later?

A. It was safer for animals.
B. It was faster and more efficient for transporting goods.
C. It connected fewer countries.
D. It was cheaper than land transport in every situation.

Answer key

30. German **31.** diplomat **32.** papermaking **33.** empire **34.** C

35. B